> Somasundaram Pillai: For these two things, it is Mr Ashe who is the cause. Generally, all white people should be killed. He is the chief officer of the district, Mr Ashe. He should be first killed … He has spoiled the Steam Navigation Company. It is he that sent to jail those who worked for the country, viz. Subramania Siva and Chidambaram Pillai. First, he should be murdered, and the other white people should be killed afterwards.[56]

The contention of the prosecution was fully accepted by the court.

> Tuticorin was a centre of *Swadeshi* activity and those who were advocating the fostering of *Swadeshi* industries and *Boycott* of English goods came into conflict with the European non-official community and the officials, among them Mr Ashe was believed by them to have used his official position to strangle these industries.
>
> The murder of Mr Ashe by Vanchi was due mainly to the impression that he ruined the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company to benefit his country-men and Vanchi was nerved to undertake it …[57]



How did VOC himself react to the news of Ashe's murder?

Though known for his large-heartedness, VOC never forgave Ashe for the ruin of his shipping company. VOC had been transferred to Cannanore (present-day Kannur in north Kerala) Central Jail in December 1910 after nearly two and a half years in Coimbatore Central Jail. On the night of 18 June 1911, at about 6 p.m. in the evening, when he had retired to his cell, VOC heard his name being called out repeatedly. Opening his eyes, VOC espied the prison's junior sub-assistant surgeon who asked him if he knew Ashe. He replied, 'I knew him only too well. He is responsible for my being in jail and for the crushing of SSNCo.' When the medical officer broke the news of his assassination, VOC exclaimed, 'Thanks for the good news. May you live long [for carrying these glad tidings]!' When the indignant medical officer warned him that he would ensure the cancellation of the Coronation remission, VOC declared with disdain that he did not care even if he were to spend his whole life in prison.[58] Justice C. Sankaran Nair's phrase, 'bitter hostility', aptly captures VOC's sentiment in this matter.